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Mulaqat Afzal

Vinod K. Jose

A rusted table, and behind it stood a well-built man in uniform holding a spoon. Visitors, all of whom looked habituated to the routine, queued up with their plastic bags containing food open for inspection. The security man stirred the thick curries—Malai Kofta, Shahi Paneer, Alu-baingan—mechanically separating each piece of vegetable from the other. Sometimes he smelt and even tasted the food. A middle-aged woman, an early-teenage boy, and then it was my turn. It was around 4.30 in the afternoon.

The security man put his spoon on the table and frisked me thoroughly, thrice. When the metal detector beeped, I had to remove my belt, steel watch and keys till the man, bearing the badge of Tamilnadu Special Police (TSP), was satisfied. This was the fourth security drill I had had to go through to get into the High Risk Ward of Prison No 3 in Tihar Central Prison. I was on my way to meet Mohammad Afzal, one of the most talked about men in recent Indian history.

In a room with many tiny cubicles, visitor and inmate were separated by thick glass and iron grills. There was a mike and a speaker fixed on the wall, but the sound was poor and people in all the cubicles put their ears to the wall to hear. Mohammad Afzal was waiting for me on the other side, a short man in his mid-thirties, wearing a white kurta-paijama, a Reynolds pen in his pocket. He appeared calm, and gave an impression of great dignity. He spoke in a clear, polite voice: 'How are you, sir?'

'I'm fine,' I said. Should I ask the same question of a man on death row? I was apprehensive for a moment, but then I did.

'Very fine. Thank you, sir,' he answered warmly.